Prince Abbas Mirza from going ahead with the attack. Nevertheless, Wade now played on these fears, writing to the Governor General that 'the opinion that Russia is connected with these events has gained an ascendency in the minds of men . . .'[78] He was emphatic: if something was not done and Shuja not replaced on his old throne as shah, Russia would gain control of Herat and use it as the ideal forward base for an invasion of India.

Along with his letter, Wade sent the Governor General an illuminated Persian manuscript from Shah Shuja, in which he formally asked for British assistance in what he described as a bid to outflank the Russian interference in Afghanistan. He had buried his former differences with his old enemy Ranjit Singh, he wrote, and he now wanted to return to Afghanistan and lead the resistance to the new joint Russo-Persian threat. While Ranjit Singh would create a diversion by attacking Peshawar, he would take his force by a southern route and lay siege to Kandahar. 'The conquest of my country is an affair of easy attainment,' he wrote. 'With six lakh rupees, I am confident that I shall be able to establish my authority in Afghanistan . . . The people of Afghanistan are anxious for my arrival, and would flock to my standard, and acknowledge no other Chief . . . The Barakzais are not the people around whom the Afghans will rally . . . If I can raise a loan even of two or three lakh rupees, I entertain every expectation that with the favour of God, my object will be accomplished.'[79]

On 1 December 1832, William Fraser, who had recently been appointed the Resident in Delhi, began to receive reports from his informers in the city that there were Afghans in the bazaars buying up very large quantities of arms and ammunition. It was unclear whether these sales were legitimate, or what they were for, so Fraser had the dealers arrested and their purchases impounded. He then wrote to Calcutta to ask what should be done with the men.[80]

An answer arrived at Fraser's Residency direct from the office of the Governor General Lord Bentinck. The dealers, it explained, were as they had claimed agents of Shah Shuja. They had been sent to Delhi to buy muskets, uniforms, ammunition, flints, buttons and cartridge pouches for his long-planned reconquest of his kingdom – all with the Governor General's covert assent and assistance. Shah Shuja was preparing for a